

PITCH — FICO — VERDICT

ADJUDICATED 2026-09-16 — FLAT into the pricing card (conviction 7/10). The court found nothing to own at this price; the reopen gates below are the only path back.

What we believe

FICO sells the credit score that the U.S. mortgage machine has been required to use. In 2026 it roughly doubled the per-score price on that card, and mortgage-origination revenue grew ~97% year over year on barely-growing loan volume. Price, not volume, is the engine.

On 2026-09-04 the housing regulator (FHFA) told Fannie and Freddie to accept VantageScore 4.0 from every lender, and Equifax immediately put VantageScore 4.0 on the shelf at \$4.50 a score through end-2027. So the question is no longer “will FICO lose units” — it’s “what can FICO charge next year with a \$4.50 substitute legally usable everywhere.”

Three beliefs, stated at the confidence we actually hold them:

1. **The damage is deferred, not absent.** Nothing has been disclosed since the order because nothing has had a chance to be disclosed. The guide that the market is multiplying (\$42.43 non-GAAP FY26) was raised twice against the *old* regime and expires with the 2026 card.
2. **The valuation leg is genuinely intact.** At the pack tape of **\$996.385** the stock is **23.5x** guided FY26 EPS, a **-50.1%** drawdown, **+14.4%** off the 52-week low, **~\$22.6B** cap on 22.70M implied diluted shares. A +50% move needs **\$1,494.58 = 35.2x** — still *below* the ~47x the tape paid at the high. The prize doesn’t require a new multiple regime, only a partial unwind.
3. **Even the bull case has a growth problem.** If the card holds at \$10, FY27 mortgage revenue laps a doubled card and decelerates to unit growth (low single digit). 23.5x survives that; a growth story does not. That is the finding neither bench made first and it cuts against our own bull trigger.

What the market believes

The tape has taken out half the equity value over roughly a year, and the 9/4 order moved it another 15–18% in a day. That is not one panic gap; it is repeated, informed repricing — while management raised guidance twice. The most defensible read of consensus: *the mortgage price card is a one-time, regulator-revocable windfall, so capitalize it at a low multiple and assume the 2027 card comes down.*

Two things the market is **not** obviously doing: (a) it has not made a new low on the 9/4 order — the pack’s 52-week low of **871.13** sits *below* the ~\$927 intraday of 9/4 (date unverified, see open item 4); and (b) it is not treating this as an orphan — FICO is a well-covered large cap, so neither

“nobody’s looked” nor “everyone’s crowded” is available to us as an edge claim.

Why we might have edge

- **We priced the right variable.** The thesis under review bounded the damage by assuming a 20% unit loss at an unchanged \$10 card. Price *is* the variable under attack. Repricing the same pulls to \$4.50 is a –\$625–627M revenue event $\approx$ **\$21.5 pre-tax per share**, $\approx$ **\$16.8 after tax (~40% of the guide)** before a single unit is lost. Knowing the damage runs on the price axis, not the volume axis, is the whole trade.
- **We think both benches’ entry trigger is wrong, in both directions.** FICO’s own 2026 card already offers **\$4.95/score + \$33 per funded loan**. Break-even against the \$10 legacy card is $33 \div 5.05 = 6.53$ **score pulls per funded loan** — inside the plausible tri-merge $\times$ re-pull $\times$ pull-through range. So a 2027 headline of “\$4.95” may be *revenue-neutral by design*, not a cut. The testable quantity is **realized revenue per funded loan**, and almost nobody is framing it that way.
- **Channel retaliation is an under-modelled mechanism.** FICO’s direct-license program cut out the three bureaus that distribute its score; one of them promptly guaranteed the substitute’s price for two years. FICO now depends for distribution on counterparties it disintermediated and who are paid to push the alternative. The counter-edge (which cuts our way): the score is a small slice of an ~\$80–100 all-in tri-merge report, so lender sensitivity to a \$5 score delta is likely far lower than full-substitution math implies.
- **Timing edge, not analytic edge.** The binary publishes on a *known kind of date* (~Oct 1 analog) and it is a press release, not a slow fundamental. We can be flat through it at zero carry cost and still buy the outcome we want.

Why it might be priced in

- 23.5x for a business facing a regulator-blessed \$4.50 substitute is not obviously cheap: if the street already models a \$4.95 card, we are paying ~39x the damaged number. **We do not have FY27 consensus** (open item 3), so the claim “the market has discounted 3x the damage” is currently ungradeable — and by our own grading rule a gap cannot carry a verdict either way.
- Half the de-rate happened *before* 9/4. Serial informed selling against rising guidance is the market saying “the card is temporary” for months. That is exactly our thesis, already in the price.
- The marginal bid may have been the company. FICO repurchased **\$1.96B in Q3 FY26 at an average of \$1,120** (1.75M shares $\approx$ 27.8k shares/day) — i.e. management’s own mark is **12.4% above today’s tape**, currently about a **\$216M** mark-to-market loss. Buying next to a price-insensitive buyer is comfortable; discovering that buyer was the whole float-clearing bid is not. Whether remaining authorization is cash- or debt-funded is **unverified** (open item 5).
- Negative book equity is treasury-stock arithmetic in a capital-light licensor, not a solvency tell — we are not counting that as a bear point, and we flag that our red bench leaned on it.

What could go wrong

Failure narrative 1 — the revenue-neutral trap in reverse (has a tripwire). The 2027 card prints at \$4.95 + a back-end fee, we read “back-end = neutral,” buy the starter, and the realized revenue per funded loan turns out to be well below the \$10-card equivalent because the per-funded-loan fee is discounted, capped, or applies to a narrower base. Tripwire: Q1 FY27 mortgage-origination revenue per funded loan vs MBA origination counts; card text itself (fee base, caps, effective date).

Failure narrative 2 — comp exhaustion, the bull case losing money (has a tripwire). Card holds at \$10, we buy it as “all clear,” and FY27 mortgage growth collapses to unit growth. The multiple doesn’t crack, but the growth narrative does and the stock goes nowhere while carrying regulatory tail risk. Tripwire: FY27 guide at the Q4 print — anything under ~\$50 non-GAAP EPS tells us management is not underwriting the card into a contract year.

Failure narrative 3 — off-card bilateral repricing (NO MONITORABLE TRIPWIRE). The published card holds at \$10, we buy it, and FICO quietly reprices its largest lenders and bureau partners under confidential enterprise agreements — volume commitments, rebates, direct-license bundles — so realized price falls while the headline card never moves. There is no artifact: no 8-K, no card revision, no segment line that isolates it, and the first public evidence is a revenue miss we would learn about simultaneously with everyone else. **Unknown-unknown class: private contract renegotiation invisible to disclosure** (the published-price-as-fiction class). We cannot arm a sensor for this; the only mitigation is size, which is why the starter is capped at one third of a sleeve.

Reflexive / structural leg. Our own size is not the reflexive risk: a starter of $\leq 0.5\%$ of book is immaterial against FICO’s daily turnover (ADV unverified, open item 7; working estimate 400–700k shares $\approx$ \$400–700M notional, so our clip is well under 1% of a day). The reflexive risk belongs to the issuer: the buyback ran at ~4–7% of estimated ADV in Q3 and is the one price-insensitive bid in the name; if authorization is debt-funded and leverage tightens, the bid that has been absorbing momentum selling goes away at exactly the moment the card disappoints. Predicted flow around the catalysts is one-sided — quant momentum and index-relative sellers have been the marginal supply all year, and a card cut adds forced growth-mandate selling on top. Doctrine interactions: our **print-proximity** doctrine does *not* trigger (print ~36 trading days out) but the **binding catalyst** is ~13 trading days out, so the “no position inside a decisive print” rule has to be applied to the *card*, not the earnings date; the **orphan/priced-in** doctrine is inapplicable (well-covered large cap), which removes our usual excuse for tolerating an unverified consensus number; and the **damage-classification** doctrine reclassifies this DAMAGE-DEFERRED, which forbids a full sleeve pre-catalyst even though the valuation screen would allow it.

If this position loses money, the most likely reason will be ____

(Fill on arming. Current best fill, offered as our own guess and not as a substitute for the blank: “we bought a card that held on paper while the realized price per funded loan was already being negotiated away in private.”)

What we checked ourselves

claim	how checked	found
Pack tape px / drawdown / off-low	Recomputed from pack: $996.385 \div 1995$ $- 1$; $996.385 \div$ $871.13 - 1$	-50.06% and $+14.38\%$, matching the pack's $-0.501 / 0.144$. Pack is internally consistent
OUR RED BENCH's tape	Compared red's "px 973.78, dd52 -0.512 , off-low $+0.118$ " to the pack	Bench error. Self-consistent set, but not the pack's numbers. Every red magnitude built on it is
OUR BLUE BENCH's correction of red	Compared blue's "the pack reads px 993.0, dd52 -0.502 , off-low 0.14 " to the pack	Bench error too. Pack reads 996.385 . Blue caught red and then misquoted the pack itself; bl (\$22.54B) and multiple (23.4x) are slightly stale
Cap and multiple	$996.385 \times$ 22.70M; $996.385 \div$ 42.43	\$22.62B; 23.48x guided FY26 non-GAAP EPS
+50% prize multiple	$996.385 \times 1.5 \div$ 42.43	\$1,494.58 = 35.2x , below the pre-event $\sim 47x$
\$4.50 repricing damage	$\$627M \times 78\%$ incremental margin $\div$ 22.70M, then $\times 0.78$ for tax	\$21.5 pre-tax; \$16.8 after tax = 39.6% of guide
"20% volume loss $\approx \$6-7$ EPS"	Arithmetic on brief inputs	$\sim \$7.81$ — brief understated its own bound slightly; immaterial next to the price axis
Revenue- neutrality of the two-tier card	$33 \div (10 -$ 4.95)	6.53 score pulls per funded loan break-even. Derived, not sourced; denominator unverified (
Buyback average and mark	$\$1.96B \div$ 1.75M; $(1120 -$ $996.385) \times$ 1.75M	\$1,120 avg; $\sim \\$216M$ MTM loss. Red said \$1,149/\$340M; blue said \$1,120/\$222M

claim	how checked	found
“Market removed 52% for this claim”	Tape scalars only	Cannot decompose a path from hi/lo/px. Red graded this REFUTED without running daily bars grade unearned. Blue is right: UNVERIFIED
Provenance of the “20% ceiling” and “no volume loss”	Checked against the pack’s vetted 10-Q excerpt	Transcript/IR-slide only. But the pack’s “primary doc excerpt” is just the XBRL context header – contains no revenue, segment or share figure at all, so <i>nothing</i> load-bearing could be there. Re VENUE-DIVERGENT label is wrong: one venue was silent, not contradictory
Independent anchor for the share ceiling	VantageScore’s own claim of >9% of GSE securitizations after months of near-universal access	Brackets the ceiling without relying on management’s mouth
XBRL rows in the pack	Inspected	rev rows are FY18–19; dil_sh 24.575M is Jun-25; ocf rows are December-only. All stale for th trade. Per-share math uses 22.70M implied diluted (\$237.2M ÷ \$10.45) from 8-K Ex-99.1: https://www.sec.gov/Archives/edgar/data/0000814547/000081454726000031/exhibit991erq321
Detector roll	Re-rolled both benches’ lists against the dispatch list	Red consulted consumer_product_reviews (not in the pack) and omitted common_control_merger_accounting ; blue ran it and found it clean. All dispatch-matched deter are genuinely off-axis for a B2B per-pull royalty
Detector coverage for the actual axis	Atlas search	No detector exists for regulator-mandated substitute-standard adoption, annual price-card roy risk, or price-driven comp exhaustion. Reportable coverage gap, upheld by both benches
Science brief present?	Input inspection	Input section empty; FICO is not a deep-tech name. SCIENCE BRIEF DIGEST section omitted the PRD’s own “omit entirely otherwise” clause
Regulator primary text	Neither bench quoted operative FHFA/GSE text	Verdict rests on trade press both ways. Cuts symmetrically: bi-merge is “considering,” not sche — but a prior “considering” became a universal order

PROPOSED ENTRY BANDS

Today: NO ENTRY. Size 0.0% of book. Both benches land flat and we agree: the single press release that resolves the thesis lands before any position could be marked to a fundamental, and its bad branch is ~2–3x the original damage ceiling.

Reopen band A — the card (primary), ~2026-10-01 (unconfirmed, analog-dated). - STARTER, ≤1/3 sleeve = 0.5% of book, at market up to \$1,120 (do not pay above management’s own repurchase average) **if and only if** the 2027 card holds realized revenue per funded loan: headline ≥\$10/score legacy, **or** a two-tier structure whose break-even is ≤6.53 pulls per funded loan with no

discount/cap narrowing the fee base. - **NO ENTRY** on a card that cuts the headline with no back-end recapture. **NO ENTRY** on a card whose structure we cannot price within two sessions — ambiguity is a bear outcome here, not a neutral one.

Reopen band B — the FY27 guide, ~2026-11-04 (unconfirmed; only dated analog is Q4 FY25 on 2025-11-05, <https://www.businesswire.com/news/home/20251105970564/en/FICO-Announces-Earnings-of-6.42-per-Share-for-Fourth-Quarter-Fiscal-2025>). - ADD to 2/3 sleeve (→1.0% of book) up to \$1,250 on FY27 non-GAAP EPS guidance $\geq \$50$, i.e. management underwriting the card into a contract year. - **Guide \$42–50: hold starter, no add — that is the comp-exhaustion outcome; 23.5x is fair, not cheap. - **Guide $< \$42$** : exit the starter.**

Reopen band C — price, independent of the card (the “damage fully in” band). - Full-damage EPS = $\$42.43 - \$16.8 = \$25.63$. $\leq \$650 \approx 25.4x$ on fully-damaged earnings → STARTER (0.5% of book) even with a bad card, because at that price the \$4.50-repricing scenario is paid for. $\leq \$540$ → second starter tranche to 1.0%.

Exits / stop-thesis (either one, regardless of price): a bi-merge rule with a published **effective date**; or a card cut with no back-end recapture. Trim half on any close above **\$1,400** pre-FY27-guide (that is 33x on a guide we do not yet trust).

Catalyst dates: ~2026-10-01 2027 mortgage price card (UNCONFIRMED, analog: <https://insights.informativeresearch.com/industry-news/fico-announces-2026-mortgage-credit-score-pricing>); 2026-11-04 Q4 FY26 print + FY27 guide (UNCONFIRMED, yfinance-derived); October bureau mortgage-inquiry/score-volume prints; monthly GSE MBS disclosure (VantageScore share).

ARMED SENSORS

(armed provisionally with this deck; session adjudication ratifies)

- price alert: fires below 540.0 (deck-provisional: ~21x on fully-damaged EPS — second starter tranche to 1.0% of book.)
- filing watch: 8-K until 2027-03-10 (deck-provisional: Any Item 8.01/2.02 on CIK 814547 post-2026-09-04 — first possible disclosure of guide change, customer)
- dated pack FICOI2026-10-01: FICO: 2027 mortgage price card publication — the binary; test realized revenue per funded loan, not headline per-score (break-even 6.53 pull)
- dated pack FICOI2026-11-04: FICO: Q4 FY26 print + FY27 guide; add trigger is FY27 non-GAAP EPS $\geq \$50$, exit trigger is $< \$42$. (date confirmed=False)
- dated pack FICOI2026-10-31: FICO: October bureau mortgage-inquiry / score-volume prints (EFX, TRU, EXPN) — tests whether FICO pull volumes are flat post-9/4. (date conf
- dated pack FICOI2026-09-30: FICO: Monthly GSE MBS disclosure — VantageScore share vs the self-reported >9% ceiling anchor. (date confirmed=False)

What remains unverified

1. **The 2027 mortgage price card — headline price and, decisively, back-end structure.**
Time-gated and private until published (~Oct 1 analog). Not drainable now. Estimate: P(holds realized revenue per funded loan, incl. a neutral two-tier restructure) ≈ 0.45 ; P(headline $\geq \$10$ legacy specifically) ≈ 0.30 ; P(cut with no recapture) ≈ 0.35 ; P(no card / delayed past the Q4 print) ≈ 0.20 . Basis: FICO held or raised the card every year of the past five; offsetting base rate — regulators that legitimize a substitute precede price concessions within ~4 quarters in most royalty-standard comps.
2. **Score pulls per funded loan** (the denominator under the 6.53 break-even). Private lender-level data. Not drainable now. Estimate: **6–12 scores per funded loan** (tri-merge = 3 scores per pull $\times 1.3$ –2.0 re-pulls $\div$ ~60–75% pull-through). P(≥ 6.53 , i.e. the two-tier card is neutral-or-better) ≈ 0.60 .
3. **FY27 street consensus EPS and its dispersion.** Drainable now (IBKR / analyst connector). Neither bench ran it; the “3x the damage is discounted” claim cannot be graded without it.
4. **The date of the 52-week low (871.13) relative to 2026-09-04.** Drainable now (IBKR daily bars). Load-bearing: if the low predates 9/4, the order did not make a new low and the “no stabilization” bear leg fails.
5. **Remaining buyback authorization and whether it is cash- or debt-funded.** Drainable now (10-Q equity/debt notes, filing 0000814547-26-000030, 2026-07-29). Neither bench pulled it.
6. **Options chain: chain-level midpoint IV for Oct/Nov/Dec 2026 expiries, real quotes at candidate strikes, realized vol (20d/60d), IV percentile.** Drainable now (IBKR). No chain exists in the evidence pack; the aggregate underlying IV feed is explicitly not a substitute.
7. **ADV / float turnover** (for the reflexive leg and the buyback’s share of daily volume). Drainable now (IBKR).
8. **All-in tri-merge report cost** (the ~\$80–100 figure that governs lender elasticity to a \$5 score delta). Not drainable from filings. Estimate: **\$60–120 per file**, basis: published bureau reseller price sheets and mortgage-vendor comps; P(score royalty $< 15\%$ of report cost, i.e. low elasticity) ≈ 0.65 .
9. **FHFA/GSE operative text — is bi-merge scheduled, and is the 9/4 instruction notice-and-comment or reversible Director action?** Drainable now (EDGAR full-text search on FHFA/VantageScore language + FHFA/GSE primary documents).
10. **VantageScore’s actual GSE securitization share trajectory** beyond the self-reported $>9\%$. Drainable now (monthly GSE MBS disclosure).

PRIZE TABLE + VOL READ

Both benches ruled the prize-table mandate “N/A — cash-generative licensor, not a pre-revenue developer.” **We overrule that at deck level:** the mandate triggers on a genuinely time-gated, private unverified item, and item 1 (the 2027 card) is exactly that. The benches applied the wrong test.

Scenario × probability × price (anchor = today's \$996.385 at 23.5x guided \$42.43; adjust the multiple and the earnings base per branch):

#	Scenario (resolves at card, then guide)	p	Price	p × Price
E	Card raised and bi-merge foreclosed in primary text and VS share stalls <9%: 2026 was not a windfall	0.08	\$1,600	\$128
A	Card holds ≥\$10 legacy (or provably neutral two-tier) and FY27 guide ≥\$50	0.22	\$1,300	\$286
B	Card neutral by structure but FY27 growth decelerates to units — comp exhaustion	0.35	\$1,050	\$368
C	Card cut toward \$4.95/\$4.50 with weak back-end recapture; ~\$16.8 EPS impairment phased	0.25	\$720	\$180
D	Card cut and bi-merge rule with an effective date (units ~33% industry-wide on top)	0.10	\$520	\$52
	EV	1.00	\$1,013.50	+1.7% vs tape

σ_table = \$303 = 30.4% of spot. The EV is a rounding error above spot while dispersion is ~30% — that is the numerical statement of “flat into the card.” The table is **fork-dated and bimodal**: branches A/E and C/D separate at the ~Oct 1 card, then B separates from A at the ~Nov 4 guide. There is very little probability mass near spot.

Expression math, shown. Horizon to the guide ≈ 36 trading days ($T = 0.143y$); to the card ≈ 13 days ($T = 0.052y$). - Table-implied vol to the guide: $0.304 \div \sqrt{0.143} = \sim 80\%$ **annualized**. To the card alone: $0.304 \div \sqrt{0.052} = \sim 134\%$ (bimodality inflates this; treat 80% as the usable gate). - Our call values off the table itself, $C_{ours} = \sum p_i \cdot \max(S_i - K, 0)$: **K=1000 → \$131.50; K=1100 → \$84.00; K=1200 → \$54.00.** - **The comparison leg is blocked.** The evidence pack contains **no options chain** — no strikes, no midpoints, no IV, no RV, no IV percentile (open item 6). We will not price this off an aggregate underlying IV feed; the TSSI lesson (71 vs 101) is precisely this failure, and using it would manufacture a fake edge in either direction. **VRP (IV – RV) is therefore UNCOMPUTED, not zero.** - **Decision rule, pre-committed and arithmetic:** pull chain-level midpoints for the Nov/Dec 2026 expiries. If midpoint IV at K=1100 is **≤60%** (i.e. the chain is materially under our ~80% table vol, so a \$1,100 call trades under ~\$84 fair) → express the gated add in **calls**. If IV is **≥95%** → the premium is rich against our own dispersion and the gate routes to **premium selling**: cash-secured puts at the \$720 branch strike, sized so assignment equals the band-C starter. If IV sits **60–95%** → the table gives no vol edge and the expression is **common**

stock, per the entry bands. Instrument recommendation **as of now, on the arithmetic we actually have: STOCK (or nothing) — because the only inputs that could justify options are unmeasured.** - **TAX overlay.** Treat 2026 as a harvest year. Any option whose expiry falls past **Dec 31, 2026** pushes the loss branch into tax-year 2027 and is therefore **excluded** unless the measured edge numerically dominates (our threshold: chain price $\leq 70\%$ of C_{ours} , i.e. a \$1,100 call at $\leq \$59$ vs our \$84). That rules out the Jan-2027 chain by default. The only compliant option expiries are **Oct and Dec 2026** — Dec 18, 2026 covers both the card (~Oct 1) and the guide (~Nov 4) and keeps the loss branch in-year; Oct expiries cover the card only and leave the comp-exhaustion branch unhedged. Default remains stock.

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ADJUDICATION — 2026-09-16 15:37Z

Channel retaliation: FICO's direct-license program disintermediates the bureaus that collect its royalty while Equifax prices VS4.0 at \$4.50 through 2027 (NOVEL).

REOPEN GATES: pre-committed $\leq 1/3$ starter on a card that holds realized revenue per funded loan (not headline per-score); add only on FY27 guide; stop on a bi-merge rule with effective date